PROPS DESIGN

Props: Sourcing, Making and Running

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

The department nobody budgets for: how to break a script for props, find or make them, and run a prop table that survives a full run.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- the props list
- sourcing
- making
- the prop table
- the running plot

This is ZikShare's own teaching text, not a published book. It was written for this library and is free to read, print and use in class. The works listed at the end are the books to read next; they are not reproduced here and are not hosted by ZikShare.

Three kinds of prop

Hand props are carried by an actor: a letter, a knife, a phone. Set props dress the stage and are not carried: furniture, rugs, wall hangings. Personal props belong to one character and are kept with the costume: spectacles, a watch, a handbag. Breaking the script down this way prevents the classic disaster of a letter that is a hand prop in act one and a set prop in act three.

The list is made on the first read

Go through the script page by page and write every object named or implied, with the page, the character who handles it and what happens to it. Then add what the play needs but does not name: a glass that can be broken safely, a plate of food that can be eaten, a book that can be thrown. The list is a living document; it will double by the first run.

Find it, adapt it, or make it

Sourcing runs in order of cost: borrow from the department store, buy from the market, adapt something close, and only then make. A modern kettle in a 1950s kitchen is a design error, but a modern kettle with the handle changed and the plastic hidden is often invisible from the third row.

When you make, make two. Anything handled every night will break, and a replacement made in week two will not match one made in week six unless you make the pair together. Practical props - a lamp that lights, a radio that plays, food that is eaten - need a rehearsal prop as well as a performance prop.

The prop table and the running plot

The prop table sits in the wings, labelled, with a place for everything and a list taped to the wall. Personal props go into a labelled box for each actor. Nothing leaves the theatre without being signed out.

The running plot lists every prop movement: preset position, who takes it, when, where it goes after, and who strikes it. Every night the same hands do the same things. The props run is rehearsed like a scene, with the stage manager calling the presets.

Hygiene and safety matter more than period accuracy: wash anything that touches a mouth, do not use real glass where a fall is possible, do not put a real flame on a wooden stage without permission, and check every weapon prop is rubber or blunt before it is used.

The prop store and the budget

Start a prop store even if it is one cupboard. Label shelves, keep an inventory, and record what left and who has it. Every department that has ever produced a play owns a bottle, a suitcase, a telephone and a pile of cloth; the store is how those objects survive from one production to the next.

Budget props as a line, not as petty cash. Divide the budget between consumables (food, candles, breakaways), hire (furniture, a sewing machine), purchases (the objects you must own) and making (materials). Photograph the receipts; the next production will need to know what a beaded bag cost.

Borrow with a form. Note the owner, the object, its condition, the date it is due back and who is responsible. Return borrowed things clean and on time, with a note. A department that returns things properly can borrow

again, and a production that cannot borrow is a production that buys everything twice.

Exercises

1. Make a props list for a ten-page scene: object, page, character, action, destination.
2. Source three props for a period scene under a stated budget and photograph the substitutions you had to make.
3. Write the running plot for those three props across two acts.

Where to read more

Andrew Sofer, The Stage Life of Props (2003)

Thurston James, The Prop Builder's Molding and Casting Handbook (1989)

Amy Mussman, The Prop Master (2008)

These are books to look for in a library or a bookshop. They are not on this shelf and ZikShare does not host them.